Hannah's Gift

By Maria Housden

MARIA: **(Prologue)** Looking back, I realize that my whole life pivots around a single moment: The Red Shoes. I was standing in a Stride-Rite children's shoe store. Black or blue leather would coordinate with every outfit in Hannah's preschool wardrobe. [But] Hannah had already decided . . . [she was] holding up a pair of red patent leather Mary Janes.

HANNAH: These are ***my*** shoes! *(slipping her feet into the shoes)*

MARIA: *(smiling patiently)* Those are lovely, but we need to buy something practical that will match the dresses in your closet.

HANNAH: But Mommy, red shoes go with everything. Besides . . . they fit me just perfect!!! *(whispering)* Just like Cinderella!

MARIA: Closing her eyes and extending her arms, Hannah began to dance, oblivious to everything but the shoes on her feet. *(Beat)* **(Beyond Fear)** The two of us were

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crossing the parking lot. Her red shoes tapped on the pavement as she walked beside me.

HANNAH: Mommy, do children ever die?

MARIA: I paused before answering. I wished I could tell her that children didn't die. But I knew that wasn't the truth, and I knew Hannah knew it too. *(to Hannah)* Yes, Hannah, sometimes children die.

INTRODUCTION

According to St. Baldrick's Foundation, one in 285 children in the United States will be diagnosed with cancer before age 20. These children are true gifts. They have no interest in being victims. They change the lives of everyone they touch with their bravery, strength, compassion, optimism, and willpower. This is . . .

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MARIA: **(Light in the Shadow)** [It began] during our vacation in Michigan. We had taken Hannah to an emergency room. She had been complaining that it hurt to lie down. The doctor told us she had the flu and sent us away with Children's Tylenol. Two days later, we took her to another hospital. The pediatrician tried to examine her abdomen but she screamed and refused

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to lie down and the doctor gave up, obviously exasperated.

DOCTOR: There's nothing wrong with her; she's just manipulating you. She has too much energy to be really sick. As far as I can see, she's fine.

MARIA: Every bone in my body was telling me something was wrong, and yet, perhaps the doctor was right. Maybe I was just the inadequate mother of an overindulged child. (Beat) Now, [a third] doctor . . . He came into the room, flipped the switch on the light board, and slid the film under the clip. [There was] a large, dark shadow beneath the white outline of Hannah's ribs. I felt like a profound failure.

DOCTOR: **(A Deeper Silence)** It's called a Rhabdoid tumor of the kidney. It's malignant, aggressive and rare.

MARIA: **(Truth: A Special Medicine)** The weight of the moment crushed against my chest. *(to Hannah)* Hannah, the doctors have figured out why you are feeling so sick. There is a lump in your tummy called a tumor. The doctors are going to take it out, and then give you medicines to try to make sure the bad cells don't come back. *(Beat)* **(Magic)** A week after Hannah's

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second surgery, and as a Make-A-Wish kid, Hannah qualified for an all-expenses-paid trip to Walt Disney World. Hannah performed two somersaults in the middle of the floor to celebrate. Cinderella's castle was our first stop.

CINDERELLA: Hello, I'm Cinderella. What's your name?

HANNAH: *(in awe)* My name's Hannah. *(quietly)* I just had surgery. Do you want to see my scar? *(She raises her dress)*

CINDERELLA: *(looking at Hanna's scar, she then opens her arms wide to hug the little girl)* Thank you for sharing that with me, Hannah.

MARIA: As she held Hannah, she looked at me, her eyes full of tears. It didn't matter that Cinderella was a girl from Iowa. The joy we experienced in the meeting was real, and that was magic enough for me. *(Beat)* **(Anticipation)** Since the day Dr. Kamalaker told us Hannah had cancer, I had begun living the paradox of wanting to do anything to find a cure and needing to preserve the quality of time Hannah had left. I agreed to try the chemotherapy protocol once a week at the outpatient clinic.

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SOCIAL WORKER: You realize that chemotherapy will severely compromise Hannah's immune system. Preschool is definitely out of the question.

MARIA: I knew it was true. But to me, Hannah was a three-year-old first, and a caner patient second. *(to the Social Worker)* You don't understand. After everything Hannah's been through, I won't take preschool away from her. She wants to ride on a bus and go on field trips with her friends. I'm willing to do anything to make that happen. *(to audience)* Hannah started preschool the week after her third birthday. **(Nurse Katie and the Tea Party)** Her friends exclaimed over her dress [and red shoes] and hardly seemed to notice the paper hospital mask or her lack of hair. *(Beat)* **(Hannah's Birthday)** Soon it was Hanna's birthday. When I asked how she wanted to celebrate the day she said:

HANNAH: I want a party with a Little Mermaid cake, not too much people and not too much gifts!

MARIA: The children had greeted Hannah shyly, tentatively. It was clear they had been reminded just before coming that Hannah had had surgery [again] and might still feel sick. Hannah had been the one to step into the moment and set us all straight.

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HANNAH: Hey, you guys, do you want to see my scar? It's just surgery! *(she lifts the hem of her dress and, exclaims enthusiastically)* My doctors gave me medicine and pizza!

CHILD: Ooooo . . . Ahhh . . . Wow! I want to have surgery! *(pause)* Can you still play?

HANNAH: Of course, you silly. This is a party, isn't it?

MARIA: One of the mothers turned to me and whispered, "Is this okay with you?" And I smiled and shrugged. If it's okay with her, it's okay with me. *(long beat)* **(Say Yes)** [But] Less than a week after Easter, Dr. Kamalaker slid a piece of film under the clip of a lightboard and pointed to the spot where the cancer had metastasized. In a different place this time. Very close to Hannah's spinal cord and wrapped around some very important veins. The doctors can't take this one out. **(On the Threshold)** As Hannah's tumor grew, so did the amount of morphine she required.

HANNAH: Mommy, I want you to carry me to my room

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MARIA: It was the first time in days she had asked to go anywhere other than the bathroom.

HANNAH: Don't put me down and don't go it. I just want to look.

MARIA: The two of us stood on the threshold, watching dust dance in the late afternoon sun. The magic wand she had made at her birthday party almost a year ago lay in the middle of the floor. I wanted to wave it through the hush and bring everything back to life. *(beat)* I knew Hannah was saying good-bye, but I wasn't ready. This room with its Barbie dolls and red patent leather shoes was Hannah. If I were to say good-bye to this, what part of her would be left? *(long beat)* **(Everywhere I Am, There You'll Be)** Hannah hadn't eaten more than a bite or two of solid food for almost a week. I was sitting at the foot of the bed, early in the day, when Hanna stirred and sat up slowly.

HANNAH: *(wincing then smiling)* Mommy, do you know that even if I go to Heaven, I'm going to come back? *(deep moan of pain)*

MARIA: Yes, Hannah, I know.

HANNAH: *(deep moan of pain)*

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MARIA: **(Silence)** I jumped up, checking the morphine pump to make sure nothing had malfunctioned. Something had drastically changed. I decided to pick her up, not knowing what else to do. Hannah's body continued to fight for twenty minutes, but some part of her already felt free. One moment she was alive and breathing; the next, she wasn't. *(beat)* **(Prologue)** The truest measure of a life is not its length, but the fullness in which it is lived. **(Everywhere I Am, There You'll Be)** In that instant I knew that, no matter what happened, there was a part of Hannah that would always be with me, something of her that would never die. It wasn't a belief. It wasn't a hope. It was a knowing beyond the workings of my mind. *(beat)* I closed my eyes for a moment. And there, behind my eyelids, I saw something I could hardly believe: It was Hannah . . . radiant . . . laughing **(Prologue)** in red patent leather shoes. Closing her eyes and extending her arms, Hannah began to dance. May her story offer solace to those who suffer and inspiration to those who want the courage to live their own truth.

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